

TOPIC 04

The decision & the plan

From evidence to a recommendation a board can approve

From evidence to decision and plan

now you make the call

- You've built the evidence (Topic 3). Now you do what a consultant is paid for: make the call.
- Three moves: prioritise → recommend → plan it, then ask for the decision.
- These are the last sections of the business case — after this, the written case is complete.
- A board approves a clear recommendation, a credible plan, and a specific ask. Give them all three.

01

SECTION

Recommendation

from analysis to advice

From analysis to advice

- Evaluation tells you what the options are worth; a recommendation says what to do.
- This is the turn from analyst to advisor — you stop weighing and start advising.
- The board wants a clear call, backed by the evidence you've already built.

Prioritise first

- Before recommending, rank the proposed changes (from your gap analysis): what matters most, what's urgent, what can wait.
- A simple lens: impact (against the objectives) versus effort / urgency.
- Prioritisation makes the plan sequenceable — and shows you're not boiling the ocean.

Make the call

- State the recommended option plainly — no hedging.
- Justify it straight from the evidence:
 - the CBA result (cost over the horizon)
 - the risk / impact comparison
 - alignment with the strategic objectives
- Name the trade-off you're accepting — a recommendation with no downside isn't trusted.

What a strong recommendation looks like

- Decisive — one clear recommended option.
- Evidence-linked — every reason traces to your CBA / risk / strategy work.
- Honest — names the trade-off and why it's acceptable.
- Actionable — leads naturally into the plan.

ACTIVITY

Write the Recommendation

- In your working copy of the Business Case, add the Recommendation section for the Accounting System (Ledgerline).
- Remember to:
 - Prioritise your proposed changes (from your gap analysis).
 - State the recommended option plainly.
 - Justify it from your CBA + risk + strategic alignment – cite your own earlier sections.
 - Name the trade-off you're accepting.
- ~½ page.
-  Recommend, don't re-argue – point at the evidence you already built.



~20 min, then we discuss

Key takeaways

Section 1 · Recommendation

Prioritise the changes, then recommend – impact vs effort/urgency.

One clear option; justify it straight from the evidence; name the trade-off.

The recommendation is the hinge between the evidence and the plan.

02

SECTION

Action plan

how and when

What the action plan is for

- A recommendation says what and why; the action plan says how and when.
- It turns a “yes” into execution the organisation can actually run.
- And it proves the recommendation is feasible.

The parts of an action plan

five parts (becomes the Action Plan section)

- Prioritised changes – what gets done, in priority order
- Implementation schedule – phases / sequence / timeframe
- Standards, targets & success metrics – how you'll know it worked
- Implementation methods – how each change is delivered
- Alignment with the change-management procedure – routing through governance

Sequencing & the schedule

- Order the work by priority and dependency (you can't migrate data before the target exists).
- Group into phases with a realistic timeframe.
- Board-level — phases and milestones, not a day-by-day Gantt. Show the critical path.

Standards, targets & success metrics

- Hold the work to the industry standards (Well-Architected, ISO 27017, Essential Eight, ITIL).
- Set measurable targets: availability, recovery, cutover with no data loss, budget adherence.
- Targets make the plan accountable — they define “done well”.

Align to the change-management procedure

- Real change runs through governance.
- Map the high-risk steps (e.g. cutover) to the change-management procedure:
 - change request → risk assessment → approval → change window
- This is what separates a consultant's plan from a wish-list.

ACTIVITY

Build the Action Plan

- In your working copy of the Business Case, add the Action Plan for the Accounting System.
- Include all five parts:
 - prioritised changes · implementation schedule (phases)
 - standards, targets & success metrics · implementation methods
 - alignment with the change-management procedure
- ~1 page.
- ⚠ Board-level — phases, milestones and metrics, not a day-by-day task list.



~30 min, then we compare

Key takeaways

Section 2 · Action plan

The plan turns the recommendation into executable phases.

Five parts: prioritised changes · schedule · standards/targets/metrics · methods · change-mgmt alignment.

Board-level detail; route high-risk steps through governance; make it measurable.

03

SECTION

The decision requested

make the “yes” easy

Close with a clear ask

- A business case that doesn't ask for anything gets “noted”, not approved.
- The final section makes the decision easy: state exactly what you want approved, today.

What to ask for

be specific

- Approve the recommended option.
- Approve the action plan as the roadmap.
- Authorise the budget envelope (the figure from your CBA).
- List the next steps; defer the high-risk gates to their change-management approval.
- The ask should be answerable with a single “approved”.

ACTIVITY

Write Next Steps & the Decision Requested

- In your working copy of the Business Case, add the Next Steps and Decision Requested section for the Accounting System – completing the written business case.
- Remember to:
 - State the specific decisions you're asking the board to make (option, plan, budget).
 - List the immediate next steps.
 - Note how the high-risk steps route through the change-management procedure.
- ~½ page.
- ⚠ A specific, answerable ask – name the option, the plan, and the budget figure.



~15 min, then we discuss

Key takeaways

Section 3 · The decision requested

End with a specific, answerable ask: approve option + plan + budget.

Defer high-risk gates to their change-management approval.

Your written business case is now complete — diagnosis, evidence, decision and plan.

The case is written — now make it

You've completed the written business case: diagnosis → evidence → decision & plan.

Recommendation, action plan and a clear ask — everything a board needs to say yes.

A written case only persuades if it's also delivered well.

Next: present it — pitch the case to the board and handle the room.